

SHOWCASE

COLT NAVY REVOLVER

By the late 1840s, Samuel Colt had manufactured several models of single-action revolver fired by percussion caps. These were all variations on his open-frame design, which allowed the removal of the cylinder for cleaning, or to fit another ready-loaded one. Colt's most successful percussion revolver, the Model 1851 Navy Revolver, sold in huge numbers. Seen here is the improved Model 1861.

COLT NAVY REVOLVER

Date 1861

Origin US

Barrel 7½in (19.1cm)

Caliber .36in (9.14mm)

► COLT MODEL 1861 NAVY REVOLVER

Colt was a firm believer in standardization in manufacture. One of the factors that made his pistols so sought-after was the interchangeability of their components, which meant that replacements for broken parts could be bought off the shelf, and that improvements could be easily incorporated. Some 38,843 examples of the Model 1861 Navy Revolver were produced before it was discontinued in 1873.



Nipple

Hammer nose has a notch to act as rear sight

Cylinder engraved with naval scene

Wedge passes through cylinder axis pin, retaining cylinder in frame

Cutaway allows caps to be placed on nipple

Brass backstrap

One-piece walnut grip

Cutaway to allow cartridges to be loaded without removing cylinder

Trigger guard

Box containing percussion caps

Percussion cap

► PERCUSSION CAPS

Percussion caps, so called because of their shape, were made of two layers of copper foil with a minute quantity of fulminate of mercury, oxidizer, and a sustaining agent sandwiched between them. They were introduced in this form in about 1822.